Study Guide

In the style of Edexcel and OCR

How far do you agree that the Iranian Revolution of 1979 accounts for both the outbreak, and the length of, the Iran–Iraq War of 1980–8?

Exam tips

The cross-references are intended to take you straight to the material that will help you to answer the question.

Start by re-reading pages 118–24 of this chapter.

There are two parts to this question: (a) the causes of the war and (b) reasons for its eight-year length. In evaluating the causal link in each part, you have to assess the importance of the Iranian Revolution relative to other factors.

(a) The causes of the war. Iraq attacked first, but why? Was it because of:

- the threat which Iran's Shiite Islamic revolution posed to Saddam's secular, Arab government?
- a dispute over boundaries and/or
- a dispute over oil?
- an opportunity to expand Iraq's territory when Iran was weak?

Some of these factors, like the final one, may be linked to others, e.g. Iran may have been weaker as a result of the recent revolution. Explain these factors and any others you can think of.

(b) The reasons for the length of the war. You might examine and discuss some of the following questions in the light of the Iranian Revolution.

- Why was it not the 'whirlwind war' that Saddam Hussein expected?
- Why/how did trench warfare and the 'war of the cities' lengthen the conflict?
- Why could not either side win a decisive victory?
- Why did ceasefire calls come to nothing?
- How did foreign intervention, from Arab states or from further afield, prolong the war? Again, what influence did the Iranian Revolution have (pages 122–3)?

In your conclusion, you need to weigh up how important the Iranian Revolution was, relative to other factors, in both causing and prolonging the war. Be clear and keep focused on showing causal links (or not) and assessing their significance.